

Translation Studies

19. Grammatical TOs 1: grammatical specification, generalization, division and contraction

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1. Grammatical specification and generalisation

Grammatical specification

= a standard TO whereby a SL grammatical category with general meaning (e.g., a personal pronoun without gender specification) is rendered in the TL by a unit with more specific meaning because a similarly general or unmarked grammatical category is lacking in the TL.

Grammatical generalisation

= the opposite transfer operation, whereby a SL grammatical category with specific meaning (e.g., personal pronoun with gender distinction) is rendered in the TL by a unit with a more general meaning.



Reason:

- Both are prompted in most cases by so-called "missing categories": certain gr-cal categories (e.g., gender in nouns, pronouns, objective conjugation) exist in one L but not in another
- Plus and minus categories are discussed by Nida (1964)
- If we translate into a L which has a "plus" category, the translation will become more specific, regardless of the translator's intentions = "**automatic specification**".
- If we translate into a L with a "minus" category, the translation will lose some of its specific quality, again regardless of the translator's intentions = "**automatic generalisation**".
- Obligatory** transfer operations are very often accompanied by a series of **optional** transfer operations (e.g., if there is no other choice but eliminating gender markedness in translation, the identification of characters will be made by other means; if the lack of gender gives rise to confusion in the translation, the translator will employ **intentional specification** by using the name of the characters, their nickname or occupation, etc.)



Subtypes:

- 1.1. Automatic specification of gender
- 1.2. Automatic generalisation of gender
- 1.3. Intentional specification



1.1. Automatic specification of gender

Predominant direction: **Hungarian → IE**

Reason:

- one of the Ls **lacks a certain grammatical category**, which is present in the other L
- While Hungarian does not have gr-cal gender at all, all the IE Ls under investigation have gender distinction in various degrees → when translating from Hungarian into IE languages, the TL text will be more specific regardless of the translator's intention, illustrating Jakobson's famous words: "Languages differ essentially in what they *must* convey and not in what they *may* convey" (1966:236).



Example:

- István Örkény's short story *Eksztázis* (Ecstasy),
- the following Hungarian sentences, without their context, do not reveal whether the character is male or female:



 *Hungarian ST:* Fügét is vett, mazsolát is vett. Mélyhűtött őszibarackot és málnát is vett. Be volt rúgva. Hangosan dudorászott, miközben a segédek és a kisasszonyok mértek, csomagoltak, számoltak. Még vett egy kis zöldhagymát. Egy kis üvegházi hónapos retket. Az egész világot meg akarta venni. Táncclépésben libegett a pénztárhoz, ... (Örkény I. 59)

 Hungarian readers know from previous paragraphs that it is Lukács Kopp, who goes shopping for the first time in his life and is so overwhelmed by the offerings of the inner-city delicatessen, that he goes on an insane spending spree.



■ Although English readers should also know all this from earlier paragraphs, the translator is unable to translate this passage into English without specifying several times the gender of the character:

■ *English TT: **Kopp** bought the figs and raisins, deep-frozen peaches and raspberries. **He** was intoxicated. As the assistants and salesgirls weighed, wrapped or reckoned, **he** hummed a tune. **He** also bought some spring onions and a bunch or pre-season, hothouse radishes. **He** wanted to buy up the whole world. **He** danced **his** way to the cashier... (Sollosy 53)*

1.2 Automatic generalisation of gender

Predominant direction: **IE → Hungarian**

- In translation from IE Ls into Hungarian, the opposite TO takes place: automatic generalisation.
- If there is no natural gender indication in the IE text (e.g., proper names, or generic names for males and females like **boy**, **girl**, **man**, **woman**, etc.) the function of gender specification is fulfilled by personal or possessive pronouns.



■ Hungarian pronouns cannot fulfil this function because they differ from IE pronouns in two respects:

(1) *lack of gender markedness*

(2) *limited referential function*: Hungarian personal and possessive pronouns in general do not appear on the surface of sentence structure (unless specially emphasised)

English ST: **He** came into the room to shut the windows while we were still in bed and I saw **he** looked ill. **He** was shivering, **his** face was white, and **he** walked slowly as though it ached to move ... (Hemingway 163)

Hungarian TT: **Bejött** a szobánkba, **becsukta** az ablakot. Mi még ágyban voltunk. Rögtön láttam, hogy **beteg**. **Borzongott, sápadt volt, és lassan járt**, mint akinek fáj még a mozgás is. (Róna 163)



1.3. Intentional specification

Predominant direction: **IE → Hungarian**

- = a conscious TO aiming to compensate for losses due to the obligatory and automatic generalisation of gender distinction in the IE-H translation.
- Losses due to automatic generalisation are usually not realised by the reader, since the missing information can be readily recovered from the immediate or wider textual environment.
- But if the danger of misunderstanding does occur, it requires a high degree of **conscious effort** on the part of the translator to eliminate it → intentional specification (should be considered carefully bec. of its effect!)
- There are many ways in which IE personal pronouns can be concretised.



The simplest method is to use the name of the character instead of the personal pronoun:

English ST: **He** looked at **her**. **She** was serene and unyielding. (Christie 78)

Hungarian TT: **Edward** hosszasan ránézett. **Dorothy** fenséges volt és kérlelhetetlen. (Borbás 61)

or:

English ST: She had confused **him...** (Greene 98)

Hungarian TT: **Az elefánt** végre zavarba jött... (Örkény 104)

Commentary: The English personal pronoun **he** is specified in the Hungarian translation by the word **elefánt** ('elephant') which reflects Mary's negative attitude towards the old man in that particular situation.

or:

English ST: **He** said, 'I never had this in mind.' (Greene 109)

Hungarian TT: – Isten bizony, nem akartam – mondta az **öregember**. (Örkény 114)



2. Grammatical division

= TWO standard TOs:

- (1) separation (takes place on the sentence level) → one sentence in the SL is divided into 2 or more sentences in the TL
- (2) elevation (takes place on the clause level) → SL phrases are extended or “elevated” into clauses in the TL

Both influence boundaries in the text:
sentence or clause boundaries.



Subtypes:

- Separation of sentences (more sentences in translation)
- Elevation of phrases (more clauses in translation)
 - Elevation of participial phrases
 - Elevation of infinitival phrases
 - Elevation of nominal phrases



2.1. Separation of sentences (more sentences in translation)

No predominant direction

- optional TO

- is due to individual translation strategies (to enhance readability of TL text)

- is genre dependent

- greatest number can be found in German-Hungarian translation (empirical evidence)



“separation-sensitive” points:

- at clause boundaries
- by-products of 2 gr. TOs:
 - (1) transformation of IE passive voice into H active voice
 - (2) transformation of IE nominal constructions into H verbal constructions (verbalization)
- → both accompanied by the introduction of a new subject into the clause
- → affect the functional sentence perspective of the sentence, i.e., given and new info)
- → retention of original sentence boundaries becomes unnecessary



Example for 1 sentence in E $\rightarrow$ 2 sentences in H:

- *English ST*: ... and perceived Lord Warburton sitting under the trees and engaged in **conversation**, of which even at a single distance a desultory character was appreciable, with Mrs. Touchett. (James 60)
- *Hungarian TT*: ... megpillantották Lord Warburtont: ott ült a fák árnyékában és Mrs. Touchettel **beszélgetett**. A beszélgetés felületes jellege egyébként már jókora távolságból is észlelhető volt. (Balabán 99)



2.2. Elevation of phrases (more clauses in translation)

Predominant direction: IE → H

Example:

■ *English ST*: 2 independent sentence units (contain a finite/conjugated verb)

(1) In the early morning on the lake sitting in the stern of the boat with his father rowing, he **felt** quite sure (2) he **would never die**. (Hemingway 16)

Hungarian TT: 3 independent sentence units

(1) Kora reggel a tavon, a csónak farában, míg apja **evezett**, (2) biztosan **érezte**, (3) hogy ő **sose fog meghalni**. (Szász 17)



- one of the most characteristic TOs in IE-H translation
- motivated by the differences between IE and H in the packaging of information in complex sentences
- in the case of long complex sentences, IE Ls use syntactic compression (nominal or participial phrases) to increase the amount of info in the sentence ↔ H introduces new clauses



Example (with 2 information units):

■ *English ST*: (1) –ing form, (2) clause

■ *Hungarian TT*: (1) clause, (2) clause

■ *English ST*: Obediently **shutting** the door, Edna **advanced** into the room. (Christie 6)

■ *Hungarian TT*: Edna engedelmesen **becsukta** az ajtót, beljebb **lépett** a szobába. (Borbás 7)



2.2.1. Elevation of participial phrases

Predominant direction: IE → H

- Participles = non-finite verb forms having properties of both verbs and nouns
- Participial phrases = extended participial constructions containing a participle with its complements, functioning adverbially or adjectivally
- Hian participial constructions are less flexible and complementable than E ones



Example for adverbial participle:

■ *English ST*: ... as her father commented, **watching** for the buds on the apple tree. (Greene 435)

■ *Hungarian TT*: ... ahogy az apja megjegyezte, **amikor a rügyeket leste** az almafán. (Prekop 262)



Example for adjectival participle:

- *English ST*: ... Ragmen **struggling** with their great junk-loaded two-wheeled carts, women **selling** breads from baskets in their hands: they all lookd. (Doctorow 39)
- *Hungarian TT*: ... Rongyszedők **küszködtek** púposra rakott nagy kétkerekű kordéikkal, nők **árultak** kenyeret a kosarukból; s mind megnézték őt. (Göncz 41)



2.2.2. Elevation of infinitival phrases

Predominant direction: IE → H

■ *English ST*: I command you not ***to touch it.*** (Tolkien 147)

■ *Hungarian TT*: Megparancsolom nektek, ***hogy egy újjal se érjetelek hozzá.*** (Göncz 149)



2.2.3. Elevation of nominal phrases

Predominant direction: IE → H

- *English ST*: The people's capacity to govern itself is thus proportionate to ***the degree of its understanding of the structure and functioning of the whole social body.*** (Koestler 136)
- *Hungarian TT*: A népek demokratikus öngazgatási képessége tehát egyenes arányban áll azzal, ***hogy az illető nép milyen mértékben értette meg a maga társadalmának szerkezetét és a szerkezet működésének törvényeit.*** (Bart 194)



3. Grammatical contraction

= TWO standard TOs:

- **conjoining** (takes place on the sentence level) → two or more sentences in the SL are conjoined into one sentence in the TL
- **lowering** (on the level of clauses) → SL clauses are reduced to phrases in the TL

Both influence **boundaries** in the text: conjoining affects sentence boundaries and lowering affects clause boundaries.

Conjoining results in a decrease in the number of sentences, while lowering results in a decrease in the number of clauses.



Subtypes:

- 3.1. Conjoining of sentences (fewer sentences in translation)
- 3.2. Lowering of clauses (fewer clauses in translation)
 - 3.2.1. Lowering of clauses to the level of participial phrases
 - 3.2.2. Lowering of clauses to the level of infinitival phrases
 - 3.2.3. Lowering of clauses to the level of nominal phrases



3.1. Conjoining of sentences

Predominant direction: **no**

= an optional TO, because no L has restrictions concerning the number of words in a sentence.

Doherty distinguishes three types of strategies influencing sentence boundaries:

- (1) separation of clauses into independent sentences (GR 2.1),
- (2) conjoining sentences, and
- (3) the combination of the two strategies.



Reason 1 for conjoining two sentences: in the different character of **subject** **identification** in H and in IE Ls.

The subject identification ability of conjugated Hungarian verbs (GR 1.2) has sentence level and text level consequences:

- On the sentence level, it means that Hian sentences can be formulated without explicit subjects.
- On the text level, it means that reference to the same subject can be maintained through more than one subsequent sentence without mentioning the subject again. In IE Ls, the beginning of a new sentence requires a new subject. In translating from Hian into IE Ls the monotonous repetition of the same subject can be avoided by conjoining the sentences.



3 sentences in Hian with the same implicit subject → 1 sentence in English:

■ *Hungarian ST:* (1) Még egy kávét főzött. (2) ***Lesétált a partra.*** (3) ***Megkereste a csónakost.*** (Örkény 1. 223)

■ *English TT:* (1) He made himself another cup of coffee, ***then walked down to the shore of the nearby lake to look for the old boatman.*** (Sollosy 61)



Reason 2 for conjoining two sentences: in the different possibilities of constructing elliptical sentences.

- Ellipsis, i.e., the deletion of certain elements of the sentence, is a cohesive device.
- The possibilities of constructing elliptical sentences vary from one L to another depending on their morphology and syntax.
- Since Hian marks the possessive relationship doubly, i.e., not only on the possessor (as in IE Ls) but also on the possessed noun, the possessor is not always repeated.
- Hian sentences beginning with the possessed noun without mentioning the possessor are
 - obligatorily either complemented in IE Ls (GR 4.4) or
 - conjoined to the previous sentence.



2 sentences in Hungarian → 1 sentence in German:

■ *Hungarian ST:* (1) Bölcs és becsületes ember. (2) **A szíve arany.** (Gárdonyi 5)

■ *German TT:* (1) Ein weiser und ehrlicher Mann, **mit einem Herzen aus Gold.** (Weissling 5)

(lit: (1) [He] [is] a clever and honest man with a heart of gold.)



Reason 3 for conjoining 2 sentences:

the consequence of two gr-cal replacements
characteristic of H-IE translation:
nominalisation + depredicativisation (GR 7.4.2,
7.5.2).

 In the case of short sentences, the transformation of a SL verb into a noun in the TL (nominalisation) or the transformation of an SL predicate into adverbs and attributes in the TL (depredicativisation) may abolish the independence of the sentence, and it is naturally conjoined with the previous sentence:



2 sentences in Hian → 1 sentence in English:

-  *Hungarian ST:* (1) Nemsokára jön be Julis. (2) ***Hozza a mosdótálat, forró benne a víz.*** (Csáth 38)
-  *English TT:* (1) Soon Juli comes in ***with hot water in the basin.*** (Kessler 60)



3 sentences in Hian → 1 sentence in English:

■ *Hungarian ST:* (1) Künn nyílik a konyhaajtó. (2) **Bejő Juliska.** (3) **Egy tálcán hozza a kancsót és a poharakat.** (Csáth 39)

■ *English TT:* (1) The kitchen door opens **and Juli comes out with a decanter and glasses on a tray.** (Kessler 61)



3.2. Lowering of phrases (more clauses in translation)

Predominant direction: **IE → Hungarian**

= the boundaries of **clauses and phrases** are changed, leading to TL sentences with fewer independent sentence units than the original

■ *Hungarian ST*: **2** independent sentence units:

(1) Nagymama a konyhába **siet.** (2) Magával **viszi** a kamrakulcsot. (Csáth 38)

■ *English TT*: **1** independent sentence unit:

(1) Grandma **scurries** to the kitchen with the pantry-keys. (Kessler 61)



3.2.1. Lowering of clauses to level of participial phrases

Predominant direction: **Hungarian → IE**

- In Hian, the increase in the amount of information per sentence is achieved by increasing the number of independent clauses (sentence level units) rather than by compression or reduction.
- If translators want to preserve the functional perspective of the sentence, the number of sentence level units must be reduced in the process of H-IE translation.



One kind of lowering is the transformation of Hungarian clauses into participial phrases in IE:

- *Hungarian ST*: Azon kapom magam, **hogy régi ismerősöket látogatok meg**, visszamegyek olyan helyekre, ahol először sem éreztem jól magam. (Karinthy 285)
- *English TT*: Instead I caught myself **revisiting old acquaintances** and places, where I had never felt at ease. (Barker 28)



The different types of participial constructions (adverbial and adjectival) represent different degrees of compression:

- **adverbial** participial constructions (see above) barely conceal the predicate, and virtually function as independent sentence units
- **adjectival** participial structures represent a greater degree of lowering.



3.2.2. Lowering of clauses to the level of infinitival phrase

Predominant direction: **Hungarian → IE**

- not obligatory

- the lowering of H clauses into IE infinitival phrases is frequently found at the end of the H sentence, in the so called “descending part”:



- *Hungarian ST:* Az lesz a legokosabb, ha **bevillamosozik** a városba, **megveszi** a sonkát, és ugyanazzal az átszállóval **hazamegy**. (Örkény 1. 56)
- *English TT:* He had better **take a tram** into the City, **buy** the ham and **use** the transfer ticket **to go home**. (Sollosy 51)
- *Hungarian ST:* Annyi csomagja **volt**, hogy **eldobta** az átszállójegyét, és taxin **ment** haza. (Örkény 1. 59)
- *English TT:* He **ended up** with so many packages, **he decided to discard** his transfer ticket **and take** a cab home. (Sollosy 53)

3.2.3. Lowering of clauses to the level of nominal phrases

Predominant direction: **Hungarian** → **IE**

- not obligatory
- It is performed by translators in order to preserve the functional perspective of the sentence.
- Though sentences consisting only of clauses with finite verbs are possible in IE, and the function of indicating information hierarchy could rely entirely on conjunctions or relative pronouns and adverbs, as in Hungarian, IE sentences of such structure would become “too much fragmented”. IE Ls prefer to indicate information hierarchy by the clause/phrase relationship.



In the following example, 2 sentence level units of the Hian text are lowered, i.e., transformed into a nominal phrase:

- *Hungarian ST*: A Vörös Ökör kisharangja a tetőn lévő fatornyocskában dallamosan **gingallózott**, jelezve, hogy nyolc óra és mindjárt **kezdődik** a tanítás. (Kosztolányi 29)
- *German TT*: Die kleine Glocke des "Roten Ochsen" in ihrem hölzernen Dachtürmchen verkündete **mit silberhellem Geläut** die achte Stunde und somit **den Beginn des Unterrichts**. (Koriath 137)
- *Commentary*: Hungarian: **gingallózik** ('to toll') → German: **mit silberhellem Geläut** ('with silvery bell-ringing'); Hungarian: **kezdődik** ('to begin') → German: **den Beginn des Unterrichts** ('the beginning of the classes')

